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Reassessing the European Union in the United Nations General Assembly

Nicolas Burmester and Michael Jankowski

ABSTRACT In this article, we compare the European Union's (EU's) voting cohesion in the United Nations General Assembly (UNGA) to other regional organizations like the African Union, the Arab League, the Association of Southeast Asian Nations, the Caribbean Community, the Economic Community of West African States and the Mercado Común del Sur by using a novel index of voting cohesion. The analysis confirms previous findings that the EU member states vote, at first glance, surprisingly incoherent. However, we are able to show that the EU is the only regional organization that can increase its level of voting cohesion in contested votes. We argue that this is a better indicator for the EU's successful vote co-ordination in the UNGA than the average level of voting cohesion, which is commonly used in studies on voting behaviour.

KEY WORDS Common Foreign and Security Policy; European Union; regional organizations; United Nations General Assembly; vote co-ordination; voting cohesion.

INTRODUCTION

The analysis of states' voting behaviour in the United Nations General Assembly (UNGA) has a long-standing tradition in political science. Many scholars have identified voting patterns within the UNGA and used them as an indicator for ideological conflict in the international system (e.g., Kim and Russett 1996; Lijphart 1963; Voeten 2000) or used voting similarities as an indicator for foreign policy convergence of states (Ferdinand 2013; Jakobsson 2009). In particular, the voting cohesion of the European Union (EU) was frequently analysed over the past decades (Birnberg 2009; Hosli *et al.* 2010; Hurwitz 1975; Jakobsson 2009; Luif 2003; Strömvik 1998; Young and Rees 2005). Ojanen (2006: 13) summarizes that 'voting cohesion among the [EU] countries has been studied as an indication of the existence of a common foreign policy, or of the lack of one'.

Yet, from our perspective, the literature on voting cohesion and state alignment in the UNGA has three shortcomings. First, the literature lacks a consistent measure of voting cohesion. Different indices of voting cohesion are used, most often the Index of Voting Cohesion (IVC; Lijphart [1963]) and the Agreement Index (AI; e.g., Birnberg [2009]; Jin and Hosli [2013]). This co-existence makes it hard to compare the results of the studies, since both indices are based

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on different assumptions about voting cohesion, particularly about the treatment of abstentions. In this article, we propose a refined measure based on the IVC which helps to standardize the analysis of voting cohesion, specifically, in the UNGA and, more generally, in parliaments.

Second, the EU's voting behaviour in the UNGA is commonly addressed in single case research designs. This inhibits a, in our perspective, necessary classification of findings. We are unable to identify a value as high or low if we do not know what the 'normal' value or the value of another unit is. Yet, it is often stated that the EU has a rather high level of voting cohesion (Birnberg 2009: 163; Luif 2003: 51; Young and Rees 2005: 198), without putting this value in perspective. As we show below, a comparison of voting cohesion of the EU and other regional organizations in the UNGA – like the African Union (AU), the Arab League, Association of Southeast Asian Nations (ASEAN), the Caribbean Community (CARICOM), the Economic Community of West African States (ECOWAS) and the Mercado Común del Sur (Mercosur) – creates a rather interesting empirical puzzle. In fact, the EU had in comparison to other regional organizations a very low level of voting cohesion for a long time, which is surprising considering EU's comparatively high level of integration. This finding is in itself not necessarily new, as other studies already made similar observations (Ferdinand 2013; Jin and Hosli 2013; Rasch 2008). However, besides observing these voting patterns, none of these studies analysed this finding in detail. In this article, we address this empirical puzzle directly. Yet, we do not aim at explaining these differences in voting cohesion with regard to the level of integration of a regional organization (RO).[1] Instead, we focus on the question, how ROs differ in their voting behaviour according to specific aspects of the resolution on which they voted.

This leads to our third point of critique. Our analysis reveals that the level of voting cohesion is a rather imperfect measure for the success of vote co-ordination of regional organizations in the UNGA. We propose to control for overall disagreement in the UNGA to uncover the effects of vote co-ordination. Therefore, we assume, if a regional organization is able to maintain or enhance its voting cohesion in contested votes, we can speak of successful vote co-ordination. As our results show, this is only the case with the EU.

The article is structured as follows. First, we summarize the current research about voting patterns in the UNGA and focus on the research about the EU's voting behaviour, as well as a short discussion of the relevance of other regional organizations than the EU in international politics. Second, we describe our methodological approach including a discussion of voting cohesion indices. Finally, we analyse how external factors affect the different levels of voting cohesion.

VOTING IN THE UNGA

A first wave of studies on UNGA voting patterns was published from the 1950s onwards (Ball 1951; Hovet 1960; Keohane 1967, 1969; Lijphart 1963; Mueller

1967; Rieselbach 1960; Russett 1966). Voeten summarizes these early studies for viewing 'the UNGA as an arena in which broader patterns of behaviour in world politics could be observed' (Voeten 2013: 54). Most of these contributions tried to analyse specifically the connection between the ideological conflict of the Cold War in the international system and voting patterns within the UNGA. However, the interest in voting patterns in the UNGA decreased for some time until the end of the Cold War. Kim and Russett (1996), as well as Voeten (2000), analysed how voting patterns in the UNGA changed in the years after the Cold War. In particular, Voeten points out that the voting behaviour and the dimensions of conflict did not change with the end of the Cold War and that the UNGA is still dominated by a 'West vs. the rest' cleavage (Voeten 2013: 61).

Others tried not to directly identify patterns of international conflict within the UNGA, but analysed voting in the UNGA more generally. Marín-Bosch (1987, 1998) shows, for example, that most of the resolutions in the UNGA were adopted with a large majority (see also Ferdinand 2013: 3). Meanwhile, the United States (US) became increasingly isolated within the UNGA over time and voted more often with 'no' than any other state in the UNGA, making itself the 'lonely superpower' (Voeten 2004). Voting within the UNGA is therefore, most often, structured by a large majority of states which vote in favour of resolutions. The US, meanwhile, is more often than not one of the few states that oppose resolutions.

The European Union within the UNGA

Besides these analyses of general or country-specific voting patterns, a large corpus of literature focuses on the voting behaviour of the European Union in the UNGA. These studies use voting similarities as an indicator of foreign policy preferences of states. Therefore, these analyses assume that voting in the UNGA is not only about the approval or disapproval of a resolution by states, but that voting cohesion can be seen as an expression of state alignment.

Based on this understanding of voting behaviour, many scholars have focused on the voting cohesion of the European Union (e.g., Birnberg 2009; Hurwitz 1975; Luif 2003; Strömvik 1998), especially since the implementation of the Common Foreign and Security Policy (CFSP). For example, Young and Rees (2005) find evidence that the voting cohesion of the EU increased after the CFSP. Jakobsson (2009) focuses on the question whether the enlargement of the EU from 15 to 25 member states and the 'war on terror' affected the EU's voting cohesion, and finds only evidence for a small short-term negative effect owing to the war in Iraq (Jakobsson 2009: 549). The most comprehensive study is provided by Birnberg (2009), who analysed EU's voting behaviour based on voting cohesion indices and interviews with EU representatives at the UN. Birnberg highlights that the CFSP led to an increase in the vote co-ordination between EU member states and that, in general, EU member states are willing to co-ordinate their votes (Birnberg 2009: 223). Altogether,

voting cohesion is widely used as the key indicator for measuring the success of the CFSP (*c.f.* Bouchard and Drieskens [2013: 119] for a summary of these analyses).

Although these studies are helpful to understand how the EU votes in the UNGA, they lack a comparative perspective. If there has been a comparative approach, it merely focused on the level of voting cohesion before and after the CFSP (e.g., Young and Rees 2005). This changed only recently, when scholars started to show interest in the level of voting cohesion of other ROs (recent studies by Rasch [2008], Jin and Hosli [2013], Burmester and Jankowski [2013], Ferdinand [2013] and Panke [2013b] deploy a comparative perspective). Ferdinand (2013: 8) points out that ASEAN's voting cohesion is significantly higher than the EU's and concludes that 'it is striking that despite all the efforts to co-ordinate the positions of the EU 12, they [. . .] fall below the degree of cohesion of the ASEAN members'.[2] Rasch offers similar findings for AU, the Arab League, ASEAN, CARICOM, and ECOWAS (Rasch [2008: 226]; similarly Jin and Hosli [2013]).

REGIONAL ORGANIZATIONS, CASE SELECTION AND INITIAL FINDINGS

Regional integration and foreign policy co-ordination is no longer performed exclusively by the EU. This is also highlighted by the fact that recent studies focus on the voting cohesion of other regional organizations (ROs) than the EU. Panke (2013b) shows that nowadays almost every regional organization is actively co-ordinating their votes at the UNGA. In general, the literature on comparative regional integration has stressed that regional organizations are increasingly important in international politics (Acharya and Johnston 2007; Laursen 2010). All in all, to also focus on other ROs than the EU is not only helpful to better understand the EU's voting cohesion, but also in line with the debate on the impact of ROs in international politics.

Consequently, we select six additional regional organizations besides the EU for our analysis.[3] These organizations are the African Union, the Arab League, ASEAN, CARICOM, ECOWAS and Mercosur. We decided to include these cases because the above-mentioned comparative studies used a similar set of cases; we therefore tried to make our results comparable to the existing literature. Additionally, the selected cases provide variation with regard to the number of member states, the level of regional integration and the geographic location. First, the units of observation vary in size from Mercosur's five to AU's 54 members. It is commonly assumed that it is easier to foster co-operation within smaller groups than in larger ones (Axelrod and Keohane 1986; Olson 1965; Oye 1986: 19). Second, we included organizations from various geographical locations in order to control for possible regional biases in voting cohesion. Third, the regional organizations differ in regard to their level of economic and political integration. Among the seven cases, the EU is undoubtedly the most integrated in both regards. However, as heavy as the

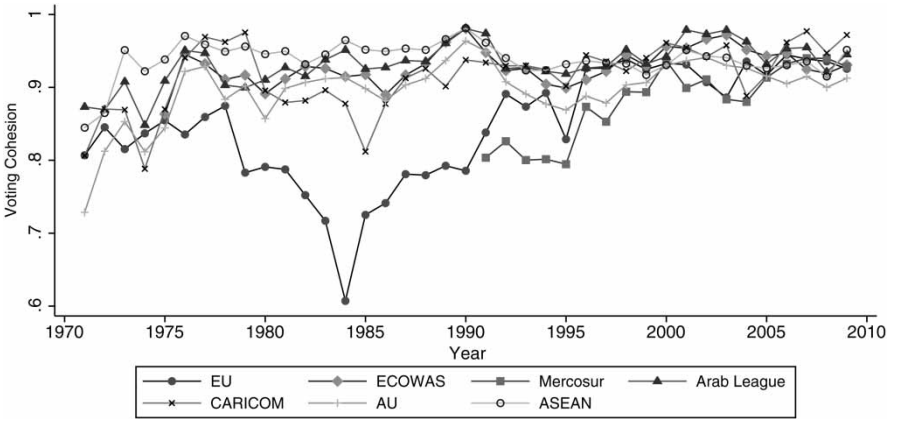


Figure 1 Average voting cohesion of regional organizations in the UNGA since 1970

literature is on European integration theory, it still lacks a theoretical tool to analyse and compare regional organizations' integration processes systematically (Acharya and Johnston 2007: 2, 6; Johnston 2005: 1036). This holds especially true for a way to conceptualize regional organizations' performance on the global level. As Drieskens *et al.* state, 'there is no measurement tool to assess the presence and performance of regional organizations (like the EU, African Union and Arab League) in multilateral settings (like the UN)' (Drieskens *et al.* 2013: 17). Yet, although we cannot measure the level of integration precisely, we can assume that a higher level in regional integration should translate into a higher voting cohesion among RO member states. Therefore, we can assume that the EU's high level of regional integration, especially political integration, should have a positive impact on the member states' voting behaviour in international platforms like the UNGA.

As demonstrated in Figure 1 and in line with the findings mentioned above (Burmester and Jankowski 2013; Ferdinand 2013; Jin and Hosli 2013; Rasch 2008), the assumption that a high level of regional integration correlates with a high level of voting cohesion is challenged by the comparison of regional organizations.[4]

In Figure 1, the EU displays the lowest voting cohesion for the majority of the period of observation. The others show a relatively stable, very high level. These findings challenge the single case studies on the EU and are in line with the comparative analyses in the field. However, this is only one part of the picture.

INDICES OF VOTING COHESION

In this section, we compare and discuss the two most prominent and widely used indices of voting cohesion. First, the Agreement Index by Hix *et al.* (2005) and, second, the Index of Voting Cohesion developed by Lijphart

([1963]; renamed by Hurwitz [1975]).[5] In the literature, the Agreement Index is used for calculating the cohesion of a group of states (e.g., the EU), while the Index of Voting Cohesion is mainly employed for dyads (e.g., the US and Russia). We consider this coexistence as somewhat problematic, since both indices are based on different conceptions of how cohesion is measured. Therefore, they produce (slightly) different results. Most importantly, the two indices differ in their approach of how to weight abstentions. Besides the discussion of the differences, we show how the Index of Voting Cohesion can be formalized in a way that it is easily applicable to a group of states.

Agreement Index

The Agreement Index was developed by Hix *et al.* (2005) to measure voting cohesion in the European Parliament, but the index is also frequently used in analyses of the UNGA (e.g., Ferdinand 2013; Hosli *et al.* 2010).

It is defined as:

$$Agreement\ Index = \frac{max(Y, N, A) - 0.5 * [Y + N + A - max(Y, N, A)]}{Y + N + A} \tag{1}$$

The *max(Y, N, A)* term is the most important part of the index. It equals the count of the voting option ('yes', 'no' or 'abstain') with the highest number of votes. In other words, it is the mode of the three voting options.

To see how the Agreement Index measures cohesion, it is reasonable to replace the absolute *max(Y, N, A)* and the *Y, N, A* terms with their percentage values, i.e., dividing these terms by $Y+N+A$ and then multiplying them by 100. Of course, the percentage of $Y+N+A$ equals 100 per cent and the *max(Y, N, A)* term is variable.

$$\begin{aligned} Agreement\ Index &= \frac{max(Y, N, A)\% - 0.5 * (100\% - max(Y, N, A)\%)}{100\%} \\ &= 0.015 * max(Y, N, A)\% - 0.5 \end{aligned} \tag{2}$$

This shows more clearly that the Agreement Index is basically a rescaling of the *max(Y, N, A)%* term to a value between zero and one. The Agreement Index does not, therefore, take into account how the states vote that differ from the majority position. This is one of the major differences compared to the Index of Voting Cohesion (see below) and, as we believe, also a major weakness of the Agreement Index, as there is a difference between abstentions and the support or opposition of a resolution.

We suggest that the Agreement Index is well suited to measure how *contested* a vote was overall in a legislative body with three voting options, because the Agreement Index measures how large the majority size in the UNGA is. Simply put, the smaller the majority size, the more contested a resolution.

Index of Voting Cohesion

The Index of Voting Cohesion was developed by Lijphart (1963) and can be regarded as the standard measure of voting cohesion for a dyad of states. It is defined as:

$$Index\ of\ Voting\ Cohesion\ (IVC) = \frac{a + 0.5 * b}{t} \tag{3}$$

Where a is the number of times two states vote the same (identical vote), b is the number of times one state positions itself clearly with 'yes' or 'no' while the other one abstains (solidarity vote), and t is the total number of times both states cast their votes on the same ballot. Conceptualized like this, the index is only applicable to dyads and it is therefore quite complicated to compute 'group cohesion'. However, scholars have done so by calculating the IVC for every possible dyad in a group of states and then computing the average of all these values (Jakobsson 2009). Yet, these studies are the exception, and Hosli *et al.* note: 'A drawback of the IVC approach, in spite of its elegance and parsimony, is that it is somewhat tedious to calculate for a large UN membership' (Hosli *et al.* 2010: 17; see also Ferdinand 2013: 9). In contrast to this view, we modify the above-given IVC so that it can be applied to groups more conveniently. The final formula we use (the complete derivation is available on request) is:

$$IVC = \frac{2 * [(n_y - 1) * n_y + (n_n - 1) * n_n + (n_a - 1) * n_a + n_a * (n_y + n_n) - \frac{N^2}{2} + N]}{N^2} \tag{4}$$

where n_y, n_n and n_a are the number of 'yes', 'no', and 'abstain' votes cast by a group and N is the sum of these voting options. Although it seems a bit more complex than the Agreement Index, the information needed for computing it remains the same. Only the count of 'yes' votes, 'no' votes, and 'abstentions' of a regional organization has to be known.

It should be noted that this formula can be seen as a more general form of the original IVC by Lijphart, as it is still applicable to dyads. Furthermore, the 'logic' of the IVC remains untouched. When one-half of a group votes with 'no' and the other half votes with 'yes', the index becomes zero (divided

vote), but when one-half of the members abstains and the other half votes cohesively with 'yes' or 'no', the index is 0.5 (solidarity vote).

Treatment of absences

In our study, we treat absences as missing values, a decision that needs a brief substantiation since scholars have dealt differently with this issue. There are four possible ways to code absences: (1) absences can be treated equivalent to abstentions (e.g., Luif 2003), (2) equivalent to a 'no' vote (at least in some cases Hurwitz [1975]); (3) as a fourth, distinct voting position (Panke 2013b); or (4) as missing values (e.g., Hosli *et al.* 2010; Lijphart 1963; Strömvik 1998). In our study, we decided to treat absences as missing values for two major reasons. First, although there might be some resolutions in which states' representatives are present at the UNGA but do not press a button because of political reasons, we agree with Voeten (2013: 55) that the majority of absences is caused by domestic or organizational issues and are not related to the specific content of a resolution. In the General Assembly, an absence in one vote is followed by another absence in the subsequent vote in 68 per cent of all cases, which makes a political reason for the particular absence highly unlikely. Second, including absences might also bias a comparison between the regional organizations. As stated above, Voeten argues that absences are mainly caused by domestic issues which are mostly related to aspects of economic development. This position is backed by Panke (2013a), who also shows that participation in the UNGA is connected to economic factors. Therefore, only regional organizations with less-developed member states will be (negatively) affected by absences, while, for example, the EU will not.

RESULTS

Based on the findings from Figure 1, we face an interesting puzzle. The EU, although unarguably being the most institutionalized organization, had a comparatively low voting cohesion for a long time. In this section we explain this finding based on regression analyses in which we analyse the influences on voting cohesion of the above-mentioned regional organizations.[6] First, we briefly describe the variables included in our model, and then present the results in the following.

To control for variation in the levels of voting cohesion, we include three dummy variables in our model, each representing a decade since 1980. Hence, the reference category is the decade 1970–79. Additionally, we include six dummy variables which control for the issue of a resolution. These variables are provided in the dataset by Strezhnev and Voeten (2012).[7] The variables control for resolutions on the Middle East conflict, economic development, arms and weapon control, nuclear weapons, human rights and colonialism. The reference category is 'other issues'.

In addition, we include a variable that measures how many members of the regional organization participated in a vote. Consequently, this variable differs for each regional organization. One can assume that the larger a regional organization, the more complex for the regional organization to find a common position on a resolution.

Further, we include a dummy variable that measures whether the US voted with 'no' on a resolution. This variable reflects the harmonic structure of voting within the UNGA. We have already mentioned that most resolutions are adopted by large majorities. Therefore, voting 'no' in the UNGA is quite a strong statement, especially when it is cast by the unarguably most powerful state in the world. Hence, it is less the 'no' in which we are interested, more the fact that such a resolution seems to be of relative importance to the US.

Finally, our model comprises a variable that measures how much disagreement is given at each resolution. The variable is based on the Agreement Index. We apply the index to the whole UNGA and then subtract its value from 1. Accordingly, the disagreement variable equals 0 in case of a unanimous vote and 1 when the UNGA members are evenly split alongside the three voting options. The effect of this variable might seem tautological, since the less cohesive the whole UNGA votes, the more likely it is that a subgroup (e.g., ROs) votes heterogeneously. Therefore, we expect a negative effect of this variable. To control for a potential non-linear relationship we include a squared term of the variable. We include this variable in our model owing to a counterfactual argument. If the outlined connection is not present for a regional organization, this can be interpreted as a clear sign of successful vote co-ordination. Furthermore, highly contested votes can be seen as more meaningful cases. As Stavridis and Pruett (1996: 4) state with regard to European Community: 'If at the time of European Political Cooperation, countries like Chile, Chad, Czechoslovakia, and China (and another 150 states) could agree, why was it so impressive that the EC states could agree as well?' Therefore, it might be more important how cohesive a RO votes on contested resolutions than on resolutions where the acceptance or rejection depends less on the cohesion of a RO.

Table 1 shows the result of the regression analysis for each regional organization. The dummy variables for the four periods reflect the findings from the time-series analysis shown in Figure 1. Also, the issue variables have only small effects on the level of voting cohesion of most ROs. However, the EU shows a relative strong increase in voting cohesion on resolutions concerning the Middle East conflict and a strong decrease in voting cohesion on resolutions concerning nuclear weapons and colonialism. Furthermore, the group size of the RO has a positive effect on the African Union's, the Arab League's, ASEAN's, and the EU's voting cohesion. This is in contrast to the assumption that fewer member states make it easier to find a common position.

US opposition on a vote has different effects on the voting cohesion of the analysed regional organizations. The African Union, the Arab League, ASEAN, CARICOM and ECOWAS vote slightly more cohesively if the US

Table 1 'Fractional logit' regression of regional organizations' voting cohesion in the UNGA since 1970

	AL	*ASEAN*	*AU*	*CARICOM*	*ECOWAS*	*EU*	*Mercosur*
1980–1989	−0.349***	−0.143	−0.147*	−0.601***	−0.213**	−0.429***	–
	(0.096)	(0.108)	(0.059)	(0.128)	(0.079)	(0.073)	–
1990–1999	0.107	−0.208	0.394***	0.614***	0.576***	0.309**	–
	(0.130)	(0.169)	(0.078)	(0.173)	(0.110)	(0.104)	–
2000–2009	0.300	−0.761*	0.723***	1.113***	1.080***	0.569**	0.903***
	(0.157)	(0.339)	(0.086)	(0.191)	(0.112)	(0.178)	(0.097)
Middle East	1.569***	0.249	−0.233***	−0.962***	−0.338***	0.984***	−0.168
	(0.231)	(0.130)	(0.063)	(0.100)	(0.089)	(0.087)	(0.172)
Nuclear	0.546***	0.00449	0.136	0.0834	0.269*	−0.561***	0.102
	(0.124)	(0.138)	(0.072)	(0.121)	(0.108)	(0.074)	(0.181)
Arms	−0.0850	−0.0176	0.0984	0.154	0.312**	0.0831	0.352
	(0.123)	(0.158)	(0.086)	(0.133)	(0.107)	(0.100)	(0.220)
Human rights	0.248*	−0.106	−0.00131	0.0306	−0.0124	0.280**	0.515**
	(0.114)	(0.119)	(0.075)	(0.109)	(0.100)	(0.099)	(0.182)
Colonialism	0.883***	1.063***	0.389***	0.548**	0.325*	−0.517***	0.189
	(0.157)	(0.244)	(0.101)	(0.175)	(0.132)	(0.080)	(0.222)
Economic development	0.549***	−0.0134	0.279*	0.383*	0.268	0.207	1.143**
	(0.166)	(0.187)	(0.115)	(0.181)	(0.169)	(0.108)	(0.356)

USA: No	1.495***	0.669***	0.971***	0.407***	0.870***	−1.012***	−0.433**
	(0.091)	(0.091)	(0.052)	(0.079)	(0.068)	(0.058)	(0.137)
Size RO	0.124***	0.209***	0.0136*	−0.0305	0.0668***	0.0506***	−0.300
	(0.020)	(0.063)	(0.006)	(0.019)	(0.020)	(0.012)	(0.279)
Closeness (centred)	−6.301***	−7.519***	−6.465***	−6.752***	−7.000***	−0.972***	−6.416***
	(0.303)	(0.408)	(0.166)	(0.278)	(0.256)	(0.163)	(0.359)
Closeness squared	3.651***	4.764***	2.132***	3.441***	3.260***	4.143***	5.890***
	(0.663)	(0.716)	(0.366)	(0.613)	(0.520)	(0.647)	(0.938)
Intercept	0.345	1.833***	1.389***	2.927***	1.321***	1.389***	3.260**
	(0.267)	(0.324)	(0.228)	(0.131)	(0.292)	(0.112)	−1106
N	3807	3800	3808	3769	3337	3808	1354
AIC	1202.0	1142.0	1556.8	1462.1	1102.0	2488.5	641.0
BIC	1289.5	1229.4	1644.3	1549.4	1187.6	2575.9	703.6
PRE	0.453	0.364	0.679	0.421	0.528	0.277	0.382

Notes: *** = $p < 0.001$, ** = $p < 0.01$, * = $p < 0.05$; dependent variable is the voting cohesion of each regional organization at each roll-call vote. Robust standard errors are in parentheses. AIC=Akaike Information Criterion, BIC=Bayesian Information Criterion, PRE=Proportional Reduction in Error.

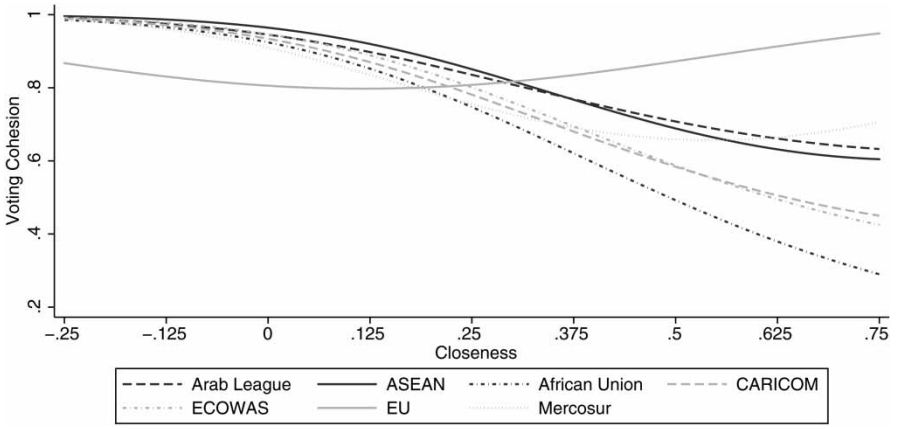


Figure 2 Closeness in the UNGA and ROs' voting cohesion
Notes: The lines show the predictive margins. Plot created by using coefplot for Stata (Jann 2013).

votes 'no'. Yet, Mercosur and, in particular, the EU are less cohesive in such instances. Luif (2003), Birnberg (2009: 199) and Young and Rees (2005: 195) argue with regard to the EU that this might be owing to the United Kingdom (UK) and France, who show a higher cohesion with the US than any other EU member state.

Finally and most importantly, the disagreement variable has a tremendous impact on ROs' voting cohesion in the UNGA. Note that we have centred the disagreement variable on its mean, which is 0.25. Consequently, the variable has a range between −0.25 and 0.75. We already discussed the assumed effect of this variable in detail above. Strikingly, nearly every RO shows the assumed negative connection between disagreement and voting cohesion, except for the European Union. This means, when it comes to major disagreement within the UNGA, the EU member states still seem to be able to vote cohesively. This connection between disagreement in the UNGA and ROs voting cohesion is visualized in Figure 2. While the EU has most of its defections from perfect voting cohesion if there is overall a huge majority within the UNGA, it shows a high level of voting cohesion on contested votes. Meanwhile, this relationship is reversed in the case of the other regional organizations.

The European Union

The overall model has shown that the EU is quite unique compared to other regional organizations. Most importantly, the EU's level of voting cohesion differs drastically from the other ROs' cohesion scores in contested votes, i.e., only the EU is able to preserve its level of voting cohesion. To strengthen our argument, we now analyse the EU's voting cohesion more specifically

Table 2 'Fractional logit' regression of EU's voting cohesion in the UNGA

	1970–79	*1980–89*	*1990–99*	*2000–09*
Middle East	0.319	1.069***	1.481***	0.766*
	(0.191)	(0.107)	(0.232)	(0.383)
Nuclear	−0.649***	−0.528***	−0.296	−0.900**
	(0.160)	(0.100)	(0.200)	(0.282)
Arms	−0.331	0.193	−0.120	−0.128
	(0.225)	(0.133)	(0.240)	(0.342)
Human Rights	−0.249	0.446**	0.428	0.607
	(0.159)	(0.142)	(0.299)	(0.416)
Colonialism	−0.303*	−0.439***	−0.834***	−1.532***
	(0.152)	(0.107)	(0.186)	(0.296)
Economic Development	−0.300	0.462**	−0.0444	0.725
	(0.186)	(0.150)	(0.267)	(0.492)
USA: No	−0.544***	−1.178***	−1.523***	−1.244***
	(0.129)	(0.078)	(0.165)	(0.318)
Size RO	0.00806	0.0839*	0.0773	0.0390*
	(0.026)	(0.035)	(0.044)	(0.015)
Closeness (centred)	−0.0931	−1.149***	−1.032**	−3.154***
	(0.364)	(0.250)	(0.397)	(0.426)
Closeness squared	−0.645	5.557***	16.25***	19.00***
	(0.906)	(0.857)	−2.860	−5.542
Intercept	1.896***	0.613	1.212*	2.017***
	(0.231)	(0.371)	(0.581)	(0.467)
N	974	1388	716	730
AIC	716.3	1118.2	355.0	288.5
BIC	770.0	1175.8	405.3	339.0
PRE	0.046	0.299	0.435	0.315

Notes: *** = $p < 0.001$, ** = $p < 0.01$, * = $p < 0.05$. Robust standard errors are in parentheses.

by running the above regression model for each of the four decades (see Table 2).

Most of the issue-specific variables have the same effects on the EU's voting cohesion over time. There are only small, negligible effects of these variables, with the Middle East conflict being one of the most influential.

Compared to the regression analysis in Table 1, the model for the 1970s discloses some interesting findings. In this period, the disagreement variable is insignificant and has no effect whatsoever. As a result, in the 1970s the EU was more or less cohesive independently of how much disagreement in the UNGA was given. Yet, if the US opposed a resolution, this had a negative effect on the EU's voting cohesion. Keeping in mind that the EU had a relatively low voting cohesion in that period, we can therefore conclude that at that time, the EU member states voted scarcely as a bloc. This

missing 'actorness' of the EU can be highlighted by taking a closer look at a particular resolution. For example, the resolution on the 'Assistance to the oppressed people of South Africa and their national liberation movement' (United Nations General Assembly 1979) was passed in the UNGA with 134 'yes' votes, three 'no' votes and seven abstentions. The three 'no' votes were cast by the US, France and the United Kingdom, and three of the seven abstentions were recorded by EU member states (Germany, Luxembourg and Belgium), while four EU states voted with 'yes' (Ireland, Denmark, Netherlands and Italy). Consequently, EU's voting cohesion was quite low (0.16), although the resolution was adopted with a majority size of more than 93 per cent.

The EU's voting pattern changed in the 1980s. As Figure 1 displayed already, this was the period with the average lowest EU voting cohesion. Furthermore, the EU's voting cohesion decreased sharply when the US opposed a resolution during this period. However, in contrast to the 1970s, the disagreement variable is significant. The above-displayed effect that the EU votes more cohesively on contested votes became relevant. On votes where the UNGA was evenly split, the EU was likely to vote with almost perfect cohesion, if we assume that the US did not oppose the resolution. An example for such a resolution is the one on the 'situation of human rights in the Islamic Republic of Iran' (e.g., United Nations General Assembly 1988). There were votes on this resolution in several UNGA sessions and most of them were highly contested. In 1988, only 61 states voted with 'yes', 44 states abstained and 25 states voted against the resolution. In this vote, all other regional organizations in our

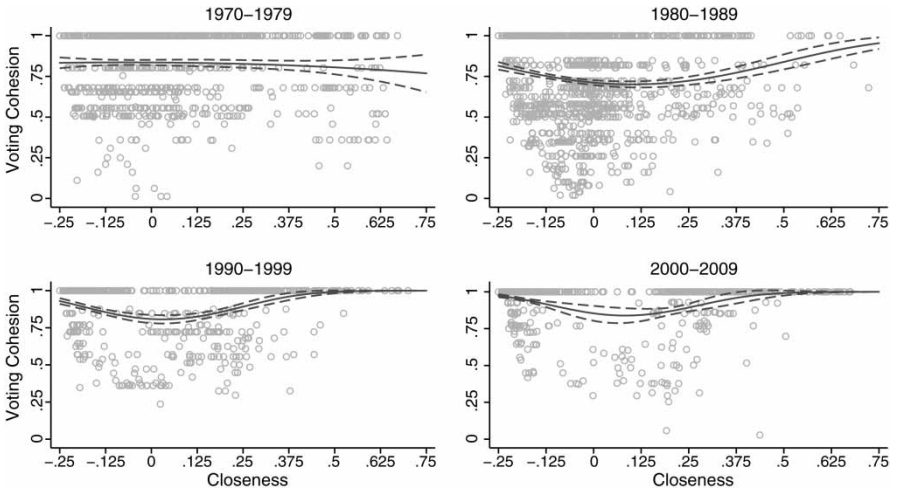


Figure 3 Closeness in the UNGA and EU's voting cohesion
Notes: The solid lines show the predictive margins, the dashed lines are 95 per cent confidence intervals.

analysis voted with imperfect voting cohesion, while all EU member states cast 'yes'.

The observed effect, i.e., high voting cohesion of the EU while other regional organizations vote with imperfect cohesion, did not fundamentally change in the 1990s. As well, the negative effect of the US opposition on EU's voting cohesion remains considerably strong. It can be noted that this is the period where the model explains the most variation in EU's voting cohesion.

The explanatory power of the model for the last decade, the 2000s, decreased substantially. This is probably caused by the fact that the variation in voting cohesion in the UNGA has decreased overall and that the EU votes more cohesively now than in any previous period. However, we can still observe the 'disagreement effect'.

As an overview, the differences in the closeness variable are visualized in Figure 3.

CONCLUSION

Our analysis shows that the EU is quite a unique actor compared to other regional organizations. However, we have argued that this cannot be derived by merely looking at the level of voting cohesion. In contrast, we have shown that the 'actorness' of the EU only becomes visible if we control for the level of disagreement within the UNGA. The EU is the only regional organization which is able to increase its level of voting cohesion in contested votes. This ability rose in the 1980s and is still present today. Hence, it implies a high level of co-ordination and strategic voting behaviour of the EU. This finding is even more impressive if we take into account that the African Union is the only regional organization in our analysis that has more member states than the EU, and that the EU is, therefore, because of its large membership, even more likely to be affected by a small majority size within the UNGA.

The voting behaviour of the EU can be described as rational. When a cohesive vote by the EU is unlikely to change the outcome of a resolution, the EU seems to put little effort in its co-ordination process. In such instances, member states can differ from the EU's majority position. In other words, if a nearly unanimous vote is expected, EU member states are more likely to follow their specific national interest, even if this is in contrast to the majority position of the EU. This might be especially true for the major powers in the EU, namely France, Germany and the UK. These states have little incentives to vote cohesively, as their voices are unlikely to be overheard in the international system, in contrast to those of smaller and less powerful states. Accordingly, it can be assumed that small states have a higher incentive to vote cohesively in a bloc, in order to enhance their individual influence through collective action, which could also explain the differences in the level of voting cohesion between regional organizations. However, these aspects have to be answered in detail by future research.

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NOTES

1 Rasch, as well as Jin and Hosli, offer some possible explanations, but do not systematically test them in their research.
2 In contrast, Panke (2013b) displays that the EU has the highest voting cohesion of all ROs. However, the definition of voting cohesion by Panke includes also absences of states. We discuss the potential problems of including absences in more detail below.
3 We included all resolutions between 1970 and 2009.
4 Only cases with at least three vote-casting member states were computed. Voting cohesion is measured using the refined version of the Index of Voting Cohesion.
5 We focus on indices which are designed to measure voting cohesion in parliaments with three voting options ('yes', 'no' and 'abstention'). In parliaments where only 'yes' and 'no' votes can be cast, the Rice Index (Rice 1928) is probably the most widely used index to measure voting cohesion.
6 We use a 'fractional logit' model, since our dependent variable is a proportion and therefore truncated at 0 and 1 (Papke and Woolridge 1996).
7 However, the coding was not always accurate, since some resolutions were coded to more than one of the mentioned categories. We have recoded these cases manually.

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